

## EXPLAINER

# The UK–Ireland Security Interface

*Structured cooperation in a shared security domain. A systems-based analysis of the shared UK–Ireland security domain, why the free-riding equilibrium has collapsed, how bilateral and EU cooperation tracks complement each other, and what implementation architecture the transition requires.*

Security Ireland

Paper 1 of 2

## IN BRIEF

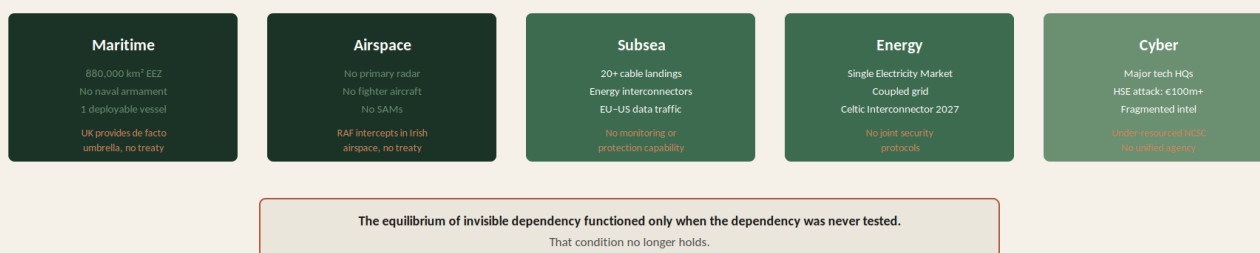
The island of Ireland operates as a single security domain in physical terms—maritime, subsea, airspace, energy, and data connectivity—and the institutional arrangements for managing this domain are undergoing a structural transition.

For decades, the United Kingdom provided de facto security for the shared domain under informal, ungoverned, non-treaty arrangements while Ireland’s institutional system was architecturally configured for the absence of military capability. That equilibrium has now broken. Three simultaneous disruptions—visible hybrid threats, EU pressure on defence contributions, and a UK shift from silent provision to structured demand—have collapsed the old arrangement.

The Cork summit of 13 March 2026, at which the two governments signed a refreshed Defence MoU and Subsea Infrastructure Framework, is evidence that the transition to structured cooperation is underway. The transition currently lacks two things: an analytical framework that explains how bilateral cooperation layers with EU and multilateral commitments, and an implementation architecture that connects state-to-state governance to the island-level systems the cooperation is supposed to protect. This paper provides the first. A companion paper—*The GFA and the Security Gap*—addresses the second.

## The Shared Security Domain

Five physically integrated domains that cannot be segmented along jurisdictional lines



Source: Security Ireland analysis based on Department of Defence, Naval Service, Commission on the Defence Forces (2022).

Figure 1: The shared security domain. Five physically integrated domains that cannot be segmented along jurisdictional lines without increasing risk to both the United Kingdom and Ireland.

## Why now: the collapse of the free-riding equilibrium

A framework that merely identifies what should happen between UK and Ireland is insufficient, as the critical analytical question is *why* a decades-old arrangement is now breaking down. Without a theory of timing, any proposal reads as aspiration.

Ireland's security free-riding on the United Kingdom was a stable equilibrium because the costs were low, the benefits were high, and no actor had sufficient incentive to disrupt it. The UK provided security for the shared domain as a byproduct of its own defence posture, and Ireland received that security without acknowledgment. The arrangement was invisible enough to avoid triggering the neutrality debate on the Irish side and low-cost enough to avoid triggering resentment on the UK side.

Now, however, three developments are disrupting this equilibrium simultaneously.

### The threat environment has become material and visible.

Threats to the shared security domain are no longer abstract. In 2023, the Russian intelligence-gathering vessel Yantar was observed deploying a deep-sea mini-submarine off the Irish coast, tracking cable routes. In November 2024, the Yantar was escorted from the Irish Sea after being detected patrolling above subsea cables while operating drones. In March 2025, a cargo ship linked to the Russian shadow fleet was observed dropping an anchor near an undersea cable in Irish waters. During President Zelensky's visit to Ireland in December 2025, unidentified drones were detected seventeen kilometres offshore, and Portugal's GNR—a NATO military gendarmerie—provided drone defence near Leinster House because Ireland could not.

These are not hypothetical scenarios. They establish a pattern: the shared security domain is being probed, tested, and in some cases actively threatened. The equilibrium of invisible dependency functioned only when the dependency was never tested. That condition no longer holds.

**The EU is forcing the question.** EU defence spending rose from €218 billion in 2021 to an expected €381 billion in

2025. The March 2025 White Paper on European Defence (Readiness 2030) commits the bloc to building a defence industrial base capable of operating independently of American support. The SAFE loan facility can mobilise up to €150 billion for rapid defence investment. All EU NATO members now meet or exceed the two per cent of GDP benchmark. Ireland, at 0.2 per cent, is the lowest spender in the Union.

Ireland assumes the EU Council Presidency in July 2026, during a period when budget negotiations will include substantial defence components. European partners will expect Ireland not merely to administer these discussions but to demonstrate credible solidarity. The free-riding equilibrium depended on nobody asking the question out loud. The Presidency forces the question.

**The UK has changed its calculus.** On 13 March 2026, Prime Minister Starmer and Taoiseach Martin met at Fota House in Cork for the second UK–Ireland Leaders' Summit. The outcomes demonstrate that the bilateral security relationship has shifted from informal courtesy to structured cooperation.

The two governments signed a refreshed Memorandum of Understanding on bilateral defence cooperation, replacing the 2015 agreement. The updated MoU focuses on enhanced maritime cooperation, cyber defence, air domain information sharing, and joint procurement. They agreed a new Subsea Infrastructure Bilateral Collaboration Framework enabling coordinated response mechanisms for cable incidents. They committed to live exercises beginning September 2026. Ireland applied to join the North Sea Joint Declaration on subsea security. Both governments agreed to explore joint procurement and government-to-government sales.

Ireland's Defence Minister, Helen McEntee, stated: 'We're militarily neutral, but we're not neutral to any of the threats that exist at the moment.' The UK is no longer content to provide security silently. It is asking for structured partnership. Ireland is agreeing.

## The equilibrium has broken

The three pillars that sustained the free-riding equilibrium—invisible threats, no external pressure to contribute, and a UK willing to provide silently—have all degraded simultaneously. This paper analyses a transition already underway. The Cork MoU, the subsea framework, the live exercises, and Ireland's application to the North Sea Joint Declaration are evidence that a new arrangement is being constructed.

However, what the transition currently lacks is an analytical framework and an implementation architecture.

This paper provides the framework. The companion paper addresses the architecture.

***The question is not whether the UK and Ireland share a security domain, because they do. The question is not whether they should cooperate, because they have started. The question is whether the transition will be guided by a coherent architecture or assembled ad hoc under pressure.***

## The shared security domain

The physical geography of the island creates security interdependencies that exist regardless of neutrality, NATO membership, or constitutional positions. They arise from infrastructure, physics, and network topology.

**Maritime approaches.** Ireland's Exclusive Economic Zone covers approximately 880,000 square kilometres of the northeast Atlantic—one of the largest in Europe. This zone encompasses shipping lanes critical to European trade and increasingly contested waters. The UK's adjacent maritime domain, particularly through Northern Ireland's position on the Irish Sea and the North Channel, means that any threat transiting toward Irish waters passes through or alongside UK-monitored space. Ireland's Naval Service operates with no functioning main armament on its patrol vessels and can deploy approximately one large vessel at any given time. It has no anti-submarine capability in waters where Russian submarine activity has increased since 2014. The UK Royal Navy provides the de facto maritime security umbrella with no treaty basis, no formal governance, and no accountability mechanism.

**Airspace.** Ireland has no primary radar, no fighter aircraft, no surface-to-air missiles, and no capacity to detect or intercept aircraft entering its airspace. Under a longstanding arrangement, the Royal Air Force intercepts potentially hostile aircraft in Irish airspace, in some cases without prior Irish awareness. The airspace over the island is operationally continuous. A radar gap over Ireland degrades situational awareness for the island as a whole.

**Subsea infrastructure.** The waters surrounding Ireland contain critical subsea infrastructure serving both jurisdictions and the wider continent. Over twenty major

cables make landfall on Irish shores, carrying a significant proportion of EU-US data traffic. Energy interconnectors link the Irish and UK grids, and the Celtic Interconnector to France is expected by 2027. The Far North Fiber cable linking Ireland, Alaska, Japan, and Norway is planned for 2026. Ireland is becoming a more critical node in the transatlantic subsea network, not a less critical one. The sabotage of the Nord Stream pipelines in 2022 and subsequent incidents in the Baltic demonstrated that subsea infrastructure is a domain of active hybrid threat. Ireland's inability to monitor or protect its own subsea domain is a vulnerability that extends to every state connected to infrastructure transiting Irish waters.

**Energy systems.** The island's energy grid operates as a coupled system through the Single Electricity Market. Energy interconnectors link the island to Great Britain. Grid balancing (frequency stability, capacity management, renewable integration) does not respect the border. Disruption to energy infrastructure on one side of the island propagates to the other in real time. Energy security is an island-wide condition, not a jurisdictional one.

**Cyber and hybrid threat surface.** Ireland hosts the European headquarters of most major American technology companies. This concentration of digital infrastructure creates a shared threat surface: a successful cyber attack on Irish-hosted systems affects data integrity and service continuity across the EU and beyond. The 2021 HSE ransomware attack cost hundreds of millions and demonstrated the vulnerability. Ireland's NCSC remains under-resourced and its intelligence architecture—split between military and police with no unified agency—is unique in Europe.

## The architectural asymmetry

The shared security domain requires coordinated institutional capacity on both sides. However, what exists

instead is a structural asymmetry deeper than a spending gap.

The United Kingdom maintains a professional military of approximately 145,000 active personnel, global intelligence capabilities, a blue-water navy, and full-spectrum air force. It is a NATO member with treaty obligations and alliance interoperability built into its force structure.

Ireland's institutional system is not merely under-resourced. The entire system—political, legal, cultural, dependency, and personnel layers—has been architecturally configured for the absence of military capability over the course of a century. This is not a gap to be filled but the *actual design* of the state.

The roots of this configuration are not accidental. The formative moment came at the end of the Irish Civil War in 1923, when the Free State government effectively disbanded the National Army to eliminate an alternative coercive power centre. That decision was rational in post-colonial conditions. But the institutional logic became self-reinforcing: each layer—political marginalisation of defence, legal constraints through the Triple Lock, cultural

illegitimacy of military spending, dependency on British security provision, and a personnel system in structural decline—reinforced the others until the absence of capability became the system's equilibrium state.

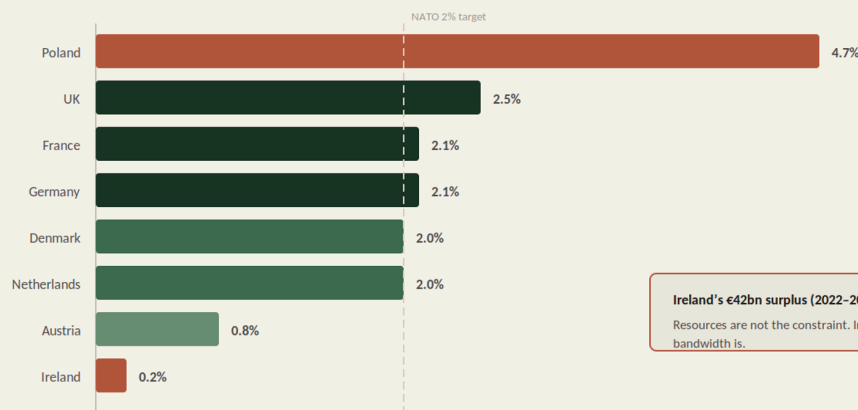
Ireland's €42 billion budget surplus between 2022 and 2024 is proof that resources are not the constraint. The constraint is institutional bandwidth: the distance between what the system can currently coordinate and what the shared security domain requires.

The asymmetry means the security interface is structurally one-sided: the UK provides the umbrella without governance, accountability, or Irish capacity to reciprocate.

***The asymmetry is not one state choosing restraint while the other invests; it is one state whose institutional architecture has been optimised, over a century, for the absence of the capability the shared domain requires.***

### Defence Spending as Percentage of GDP, 2025

Ireland's 0.2% is the lowest in the EU. The €42 billion surplus (2022–2024) demonstrates resources are not the constraint.



Sources: NATO, European Defence Agency, national budgets. Ireland figure is Security Ireland estimate.

Figure 2: Defence spending as percentage of GDP, 2025 estimates. Ireland's 0.2% is lower than every EU and NATO member. The €42 billion surplus between 2022–2024 demonstrates that resources are not the constraint.

### Threat Timeline: Incidents on the Shared Security Domain

The equilibrium of invisible dependency functioned only when the dependency was never tested



Sources: OSINT reporting, Irish government statements, Cork summit communiqué. Security Ireland analysis.

Figure 3: Threat timeline. Incidents on the shared security domain from Nord Stream through Yantar deployments, shadow fleet activity, and Zelensky visit drones to the Cork summit.

## The EU dimension: bilateral and multilateral as complements

A serious objection to structured UK–Ireland bilateral security cooperation is that it may compete with EU defence integration. Post-Brexit, Ireland's European partners could view bilateral cooperation with a non-EU

state as a competing pull. This objection deserves a direct answer.

Ireland's participation in EU defence cooperation is more extensive than its spending figure suggests. It joined PESCO in 2017 and has participated in seven projects as a full member with observer status on seventeen more. The projects it has chosen are revealing: Upgrade of Maritime Surveillance, Maritime Semi-Autonomous Systems for Mine Countermeasures, Cyber Threats and Incident Response, Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection, and Network of Logistic Hubs. Ireland has not joined tank programmes or fighter-jet consortia. It has joined precisely the projects addressing the domains where the shared island security envelope is most exposed.

Further, Ireland committed approximately €350 million to the European Peace Facility by early 2025. In April 2025, the Irish Defence Forces joined the EU's Common Information Sharing Environment for maritime surveillance. Budget 2026 allocated a record €1.5 billion to defence. Ireland joined NATO's Individually Tailored Partnership Programme in 2024. The pattern is domain-specific cooperation on multiple tracks simultaneously: EU,

bilateral UK-Ireland, and NATO-adjacent. These are layered, not competing.

The Cork MoU's focus areas—maritime cooperation, cyber defence, air domain information sharing, and joint procurement—map directly onto Ireland's PESCO selections. Maritime surveillance capability developed through bilateral cooperation feeds into the EU's Common Information Sharing Environment. Subsea infrastructure protection coordinated bilaterally strengthens Ireland's contribution to the PESCO Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection project. The bilateral track builds institutional capacity that makes the EU track credible.

The Switzerland precedent reinforces this. In 2025, the EU Council confirmed Switzerland's participation in the PESCO Military Mobility project—a neutral, non-EU state contributing to EU defence cooperation. If a non-EU neutral can participate in PESCO, an EU member building bilateral cooperation with a non-EU partner is doing something structurally analogous from the inside.

### Ireland's Layered Security Cooperation

Three tracks feed into each other. The bilateral track builds institutional capacity that makes the EU track credible.



Source: Security Ireland analysis based on Cork Summit outcomes, PESCO project database, NATO ITPP documentation.

Figure 4: Ireland's layered security cooperation. Three tracks—EU frameworks, bilateral UK-Ireland, and NATO-adjacent—feed into each other.

## The EU Presidency as forcing function

Ireland's Council Presidency from July 2026 transforms the EU dimension from context to active constraint. Ireland will chair discussions that include substantial defence budget components. It cannot credibly do so at 0.2 per cent of GDP while relying on secret bilateral arrangements for basic security.

The layered cooperation approach provides the narrative Ireland needs: 'We are contributing to European security through structured cooperation in the domains where our geography makes us critical—maritime surveillance, subsea protection, cyber resilience—using bilateral, EU, and NATO-adjacent partnerships that generate real capability without compromising our constitutional

position.' This is not a perfect answer. But it is defensible and infinitely better than silence.

**The real risk.** The genuine risk is not that the tracks compete but that neither generates sufficient institutional depth alone. Ireland's PESCO projects are modest, and the Cork MoU is a framework, not a capability. Live exercises in September 2026 are a beginning, not a system reform. Both tracks need to be layered through a common implementation substrate that connects state-to-state governance to the island-level systems the cooperation is supposed to protect. That implementation layer is the subject of the companion paper.

## Working within the neutrality constraint

Nothing in this framework requires Ireland to abandon neutrality. This is a deliberate design choice, not a concession. Neutrality is not a policy preference layered on top of an otherwise functional system—it is the premise

around which the system was built. Seventy-five per cent of the Irish public supports neutrality. Defence spending is culturally illegitimate in a way no other category of public expenditure is. Any framework that begins by asking

Ireland to change its constitutional posture has already failed.

The relevant distinction is not between neutrality and military alliance, but between coherent and incoherent management of a shared security domain that already exists. Ireland's subsea cables are already at risk; its airspace is already being protected by a foreign air force; its energy grid is already coupled to the UK's. The question is not whether Ireland participates in shared security—because it already does. The question is whether that participation is structured, governed, and resilient, or ad hoc, unacknowledged, and fragile.

The Cork MoU demonstrates that the Irish government has accepted this reframing. Minister McEntee's formulation—'We're militarily neutral, but we're not

neutral to any of the threats'—is precisely the distinction the interface framework draws. Neutrality governs Ireland's military alliance posture. It does not exempt Ireland from managing the security of shared infrastructure, shared waters, and shared airspace.

Switzerland offers the instructive comparison. Constitutionally neutral since 1815, it maintains universal conscription, sophisticated air defence, and a domestic arms industry—and is now participating in a PESCO project. Swiss neutrality was never understood as an alternative to defence capability; it was understood as requiring more of it. Ireland does not need to become Switzerland, but the Swiss model demonstrates that neutrality and institutional capability for security are complements, not substitutes.

## What each side gains

**For the United Kingdom.** The UK gains structured cooperation in a domain it already underwrites unilaterally. The current arrangement absorbs costs without governance, burden-sharing, or accountability. The interface approach offers improved situational awareness through shared monitoring, reduced coordination friction through pre-agreed protocols, and strategic positioning—demonstrating that the UK–Ireland relationship generates security value, not just economic value.

**For Ireland.** Ireland gains a pathway from dependency to structured cooperation. The current arrangement is sustainable only as long as the UK provides security as a courtesy. Post-Brexit, with UK defence priorities shifting and British political attention focused elsewhere, that courtesy is less secure. The interface approach lets Ireland

build institutional capacity for security cooperation without the political cost of defence transformation—all within existing frameworks and under the rubric of infrastructure resilience. For the EU Presidency, Ireland gains the ability to demonstrate credible security contribution through structured cooperation rather than spending metrics alone.

**For Northern Ireland.** Northern Ireland's geographic position at the hinge of the shared domain—between the Irish Sea and the Atlantic, between UK and EU regimes—gives it strategic significance that the current state-to-state framework does not capture. The companion paper examines what role NI institutions could play in the implementation layer. NI's position is an asset whose value is currently unrealised.

## The three-layer architecture

The emerging security cooperation framework operates across three distinct institutional layers. Clarity about which layer carries which function is essential; conflating them produces the kind of institutional overreach that undermines credibility.

**Governance layer: state-to-state and multilateral.** This is where commitments are made, resources allocated, and political accountability sits. The Cork MoU, the Subsea Infrastructure Framework, the North Sea Joint Declaration, PESCO projects, and NATO's ITPP all operate at this layer. The governance layer is bilateral (London–Dublin) and multilateral (EU, NATO-adjacent). It is correctly located at the state-to-state level because defence cooperation involves national-level actors: defence ministries, navies, air forces, intelligence agencies, and cyber security centres. No institutional redesign is needed here; the Cork summit has established the governance architecture. The task is to deepen it.

**Interface layer: Northern Ireland as strategic node.** Northern Ireland's post-Brexit position at the boundary

between UK and EU regimes gives it a positional value that is geographic and regulatory, not institutional. It is where UK maritime assets in the Irish Sea operate, where energy interconnectors cross, where subsea infrastructure converges, and where the regulatory boundary between UK and EU regimes creates coordination demands. This positional value exists regardless of which institution captures it.

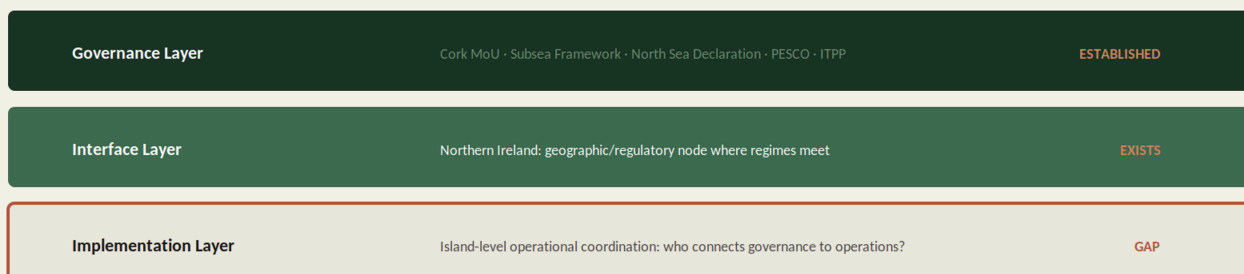
**Implementation layer: the gap.** This is where the current framework is weakest. The Cork MoU creates commitments at the governance layer, but the operational consequences play out on the island: subsea cables land on coasts in both jurisdictions, the energy grid is coupled across the border, maritime domain awareness in the Irish Sea involves assets and agencies on both sides. The MoU has no mechanism for coordinating the island-level implementation of these commitments. Who translates the Subsea Infrastructure Framework into operational routines between the agencies that actually monitor cables? Who coordinates energy infrastructure security

between SONI and EirGrid when the threat is hybrid rather than technical? Who manages the cross-border dimensions of maritime domain awareness in the Irish Sea? These are implementation questions, not governance questions. They require an institutional layer that connects

state-to-state commitments to island-level operational reality. The companion paper examines whether GFA mechanisms—particularly Strand Two—can be re-instrumented to serve this function.

### The Three-Layer Security Architecture

Governance is being established. Interface position exists. The implementation layer is the gap.



Source: Security Ireland analysis. See companion paper for the implementation layer.

Figure 5: The three-layer security architecture. The governance layer is being established. The interface layer (NI's positional value) exists. The implementation layer is the gap.

## Stabilisation mechanisms

Regardless of which institutions carry them, the shared security domain requires four tiers of stabilisation mechanism to generate lower coordination costs, higher reliability, reduced variance, and increased optionality.

**Tier 1: Friction monitoring and early warning.** Continuous monitoring of the friction points where the shared domain is most likely to degrade: maritime incident response times, airspace detection latency, subsea infrastructure status, cross-border intelligence flow delays, and energy system threat indicators. These functions surface operational stress before it escalates and they are the highest-return, lowest-cost stabilisers.

**Tier 2: Trusted operational routines.** Standing working relationships between operational counterparts: named contacts in the Irish Naval Service and Royal Navy, Air Corps and RAF liaison for airspace management, regular information-sharing cycles between GCHQ and NCSC (Ireland), and pre-agreed edge-case procedures. These

make coordination procedural rather than discretionary—the critical shift from fragile to resilient systems.

**Tier 3: Shared protocols for incident response.** Common incident classification frameworks, pre-agreed notification and response sequences, shared situational awareness tools, and defined fallback procedures. The Cork commitment to live exercises beginning September 2026 is a Tier 3 mechanism. The task is to extend it from subsea cable scenarios to maritime, airspace, energy, and cyber domains.

**Tier 4: Interoperability governance.** Equivalence mapping between UK and Irish security standards, shared technical guidance, change-notification routines, and maintained records of alignment and divergence. This tier ensures cooperation remains functional as each jurisdiction's systems evolve independently. It does not require formal harmonisation—only administrative mechanisms that preserve functional alignment.

### Four Tiers of Stabilisation

From friction monitoring to interoperability governance: each tier builds on the one below



Source: Security Ireland analysis. Framework based on coordination architecture theory.

Figure 6: Four tiers of stabilisation. From friction monitoring (highest return, lowest cost) to interoperability governance. Each tier builds on the one below.

## Implementation pathway

The following sequence builds on the Cork summit commitments. Each step is independently valuable; if the process stalls, what has been built remains useful.

**Phase 1: Foundation (months 0–12).** The Cork summit has begun this phase. The refreshed MoU, the Subsea Framework, and the September 2026 exercise commitment are Phase 1 actions. The task is to deepen them: map the shared domain in operational detail across all five domains, establish named contacts and standing liaison, and commission a joint friction audit of current coordination gaps before the September exercises. Simultaneously, integrate the bilateral track with EU commitments. Ireland's PESCO maritime surveillance and critical seabed infrastructure projects should receive data and intelligence generated through bilateral cooperation. The North Sea Joint Declaration application should be completed and operational participation established.

**Phase 2: Routinisation (months 12–24).** Activate Tier 2 mechanisms: standing meetings, regular information-

sharing cycles, agreed edge-case procedures. Expand exercises from subsea cable scenarios to maritime, cyber, and energy domains. Prepare for the Irish primary radar programme (target 2028) by establishing the technical framework for radar data sharing—the single most consequential capability development in the pipeline. Identify and begin addressing the implementation gap. Which island-level coordination functions are needed but have no institutional home? This assessment feeds directly into the companion paper's analysis of GFA re-instrumentation.

**Phase 3: Integration (months 24–36).** Formalise shared protocols for incident response across all domains. Establish interoperability governance mechanisms. Integrate the radar data-sharing framework as Irish primary radar becomes operational. Assess what institutional arrangements are needed at the implementation layer and whether existing cross-border mechanisms can carry the load.

## Risks and constraints

**Politicisation.** Security cooperation is vulnerable to being framed in ways that trigger the neutrality debate. The mitigation is that the Cork MoU has already been signed, publicly, with the Defence Minister stating neutrality is 'fully respected.' The political ground has been prepared; the task is to build operational depth before the political window closes.

**Asymmetric capacity.** The UK can implement most mechanisms immediately, whereas Ireland faces institutional bandwidth constraints. The phased approach accommodates this asymmetry.

**Dependency reinforcement.** Structured cooperation risks entrenching dependency. The mitigation is reciprocal design: Ireland contributes maritime monitoring data, cyber threat intelligence, and infrastructure assessments, changing the relationship from dependency to cooperation.

**Implementation gap persistence.** The Cork MoU addresses governance but not implementation. If the island-level coordination layer is not built, commitments will remain declaratory. This risk is the subject of the companion paper.

## Conclusion

The island of Ireland is a single security domain. For decades it was managed through an unstable but persistent equilibrium of informal UK provision and Irish free-riding; but that equilibrium has broken under the simultaneous pressure of visible hybrid threats, EU demands for defence contribution, and a UK shift from silent provision to structured demand.

The Cork summit of 13 March 2026 is evidence that the transition to structured cooperation is underway. The refreshed Defence MoU, the Subsea Infrastructure Framework, the live exercises, and Ireland's application to the North Sea Joint Declaration establish the governance layer. The bilateral and EU tracks are complements, not competitors, building institutional capacity through layered, domain-specific cooperation that works within the neutrality constraint.

What the transition currently lacks is an *implementation layer*: an institutional mechanism that connects state-to-state governance to the island-level systems the cooperation is supposed to protect. The governance is set. The interface position exists. The gap is operational. Filling that gap is the subject of the companion paper.

***The transition from dependency to structured cooperation is underway; the governance layer is being built, but the implementation layer is not. That is where the architecture is weakest, and where it matters most.***

**WHY THIS MATTERS NOW**

The Cork summit has begun the transition to structured security cooperation. Ireland's EU Council Presidency (July–December 2026) creates both the opportunity and the obligation to demonstrate credible security contribution. The layered cooperation approach—EU frameworks, bilateral UK–Ireland, and NATO-adjacent partnerships—provides the narrative and the institutional architecture Ireland needs. But the implementation layer—connecting state-to-state governance to island-level operational reality—remains the critical gap.

**SERIES CONTEXT**

Paper 1 of 2. Companion paper: *The GFA and the Security Gap—Why Northern Ireland Was Bypassed*. This series applies Sinéad O'Sullivan's coordination architecture framework to UK–Ireland strategic relations.

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